



CHANNEL Z0 – IDEAS & ROADMAP (STATION BULLETIN Nº 2)

DOC NO. RL-Z0-IDEAS-A REV. A RIPOSTE LABORATORIES

A local channel is a premise, not a product; it can keep growing without ever getting bigger. This is the writers' room – what's already on the air, and what's sketched on the whiteboard. Steal freely; the plumbing is MIT.

SEC.01

SHIPPED IN THIS PASS

These went from idea to implementation and are in the repo now.

- ▶ **The live marquee.** The storefront's "NOW SHOWING" used to read from a hand-typed schedule. Now `playout/nowplaying.py` reads what ErsatzTV is **actually** airing from its XMLTV guide and writes it into Owncast's stream title; the site shows the real program, live. Ships as an optional service in `playout/compose.yml` (`--profile nowplaying`). This is the difference between a webpage about a channel and a webpage **tuned to** one.
- ▶ **The whole home side in one file.** `playout/compose.yml` containerizes master control – ErsatzTV, the uplink relay (an `ffmpeg -c copy` loop that replaces the `systemd` unit), and the marquee – so it drops onto a Proxmox LXC or TrueNAS box without ceremony. See `docs/self-hosting.md` RL-Z0-SELF-HOSTING.
- ▶ **Station identity, generated.** The build guide asked for bumpers, a channel bug, and a technical-difficulties slate, then never made them. Now:
 - ▶ `tools/make-ident.sh` – the "NOW WATCHING CHANNEL Z0" bumpers the Station ID filler rotates.
 - ▶ `tools/make-slate.sh` – full-screen slate cards (technical difficulties, sign-off, please-stand-by), 1080p, on-brand.
 - ▶ `tools/make-bug.sh` – the transparent channel bug PNG for ErsatzTV's watermark. All three speak the storefront's language – monospace on ink, one red, the RL-Z0 designation – so the on-screen channel and the website look like one station.
- ▶ **The bookends of the broadcast day.** The two pieces of furniture that top and tail a day of television, generated on brand:
 - ▶ `tools/make-testcard.sh` – the station test card. Not raw `smpthdbars` but the card **with the station's name on it**: geometry grid, colour bars, a greyscale step wedge, corner castellations, a centre identity panel, and a 1 kHz line-up tone. The pre-06:00 sign-on fill, and a picture the tower can align to.
 - ▶ `tools/make-signoff.sh` – the nightly sign-off. The "THIS CONCLUDES OUR BROADCAST DAY / GOODNIGHT, LOCALS" card dissolving into a tail of colour bars, one file for the 00:00 SIGN-OFF item. The seed of the sign-off anthem below, close at hand.

-
- ▶ **Pre-flight for spots.** `tools/check-ad.sh` reads a submission and tells you its length, codecs, and true loudness before you accept it – the screening step that pairs with `normalize-ad.sh`.
 - ▶ **The broadcast week, written down.** The build guide gave master control a one-paragraph "starting rhythm" and an empty ErsatzTV; now `docs/programming.md` `RL-Z0-PROGRAMMING` is the whole week – five dayparts, a protected 19:00 flagship, themed nights (Atomic Tuesday, Friday Night Feature, the Saturday double bill), the show bible for what's ours, and the exact ErsatzTV mapping (collections, fixed-start anchors, the weekend schedule). The storefront's program grid (`site/index.html`) is now its machine-readable twin: a real seven-day `WEEK` with day tabs, so viewers can flip through the week, not just today. Guide and guide-on-the-wall, in sync.
 - ▶ **On Cloudflare.** The storefront ships to Cloudflare (Workers Static Assets) (`ch0.ripostelabs.xyz` today, `channelz0.tv` when purchased) with tidy short links (`/watch`, `/lab`) and security headers. The tower stays on the VPS.

SEC.02

ON THE WORKBENCH

Sketches worth building next, roughly in order of bang-for-effort.

PROGRAMMING

- ▶ **The Neighbourhood Desk, for real.** A `bulletin.json` the storefront renders as a scrolling ticker – lost cats, garage sales, the school play. Locals are the content; the ticker is the cheapest possible community TV.
- ▶ **Ask the alien.** A submission form (a Cloudflare Worker → email or R2) where locals leave questions for the Ground Zero correspondent to ask the neighbourhood via baguette. Turns viewers into a writers' room.
- ▶ **The sign-off anthem.** A 60-90s nightly close – a slow pan over the lab, the RL-Z0 card, a bit of music you own – generated once and aired at 00:00 before the colour bars. `make-slate.sh` is the seed; this is its cinematic cousin.
- ▶ **Emergency Broadcast crawl.** A parody EAS: the checker band, the two-tone, a crawl of gloriously low-stakes alerts ("A CASSEROLE HAS BEEN LEFT UNATTENDED"). Aired rarely, on purpose.

ON-AIR POLISH

- ▶ **Lower-thirds kit.** An ffmpeg/overlay template for Ground Zero – name, location, "DEFINITELY HUMAN" – so field interviews get a broadcast chyron.
- ▶ **The QR corner.** A tiny static QR to the storefront, burned into the bug area during idents, so anyone who wanders past a TV can find the stream.

THE SITE

- ▶ **Full week guide.** ErsatzTV already serves XMLTV; a small build step could turn a week of it into a printable TV-guide page (very on-brand as a zine).
- ▶ **Receiver map / "who's tuned in."** Owncast reports viewer counts; a sparkline of the day's audience makes the "someone's always watching" promise visible.

THE BIGGER SWING

- ▶ **Channel Z1.** The architecture is per-channel, not per-station. A second ErsatzTV channel + a second Owncast is a sibling network (Z1: overnight ambient? all-cartoons?). The storefront becomes a dial.

Ideas are cheap; airtime is free while we're small. Build the ones that make the neighbourhood lean in.

SOURCE docs/ideas.tex SHA 6ac5ca94515d BUILT 2026-09-07